## THE CREDIBILITY OF SOURCES

We turn now from the credibility of claims themselves to the credibility of the sources from which we get them. We are automatically suspicious of certain sources of information. (If you were getting a divorce, you wouldn't ordinarily turn to your spouse's attorney for advice.) We'll look at several factors that should influence how much credence we give to a source.

### Interested Parties

We'll begin with a very important general rule for deciding whom to trust. Our rule makes use of two correlative concepts, interested parties and disinterested parties:

> Gold and silver are money, Everything else is credit.
>
> —J. P. Morgan

> A person who stands to gain from our belief in a claim is known as an **interested party,** and interested parties must be viewed with much more suspicion than **disinterested parties,** who have no stake in our belief one way or another.

It would be hard to overestimate the importance of this rule—in fact, if you were to learn only one thing from this book, this would be a good candidate. Of course, not all interested parties are out to hoodwink us, and certainly not all disinterested parties have good information. But, all things considered, the rule of trusting the latter before the former is an important weapon in the critical thinking armory.

We'll return to this topic later, both in the text and in exercises.

## Not All That Glitters

When the U.S. dollar began to decline seriously in about 2004, quite a few financial "experts" claimed that gold is one of the few ways to protect one's wealth and provide a hedge against inflation. Some of their arguments make some good sense, but it's worth pointing out that many of the people advocating the purchase of gold turn out to be brokers of precious metals themselves, or are hired by such brokers to sell their product. As we emphasize in the text: Be wary of interested parties.

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### Physical and Other Characteristics

The feature of being an interested or disinterested party is highly relevant to whether he, she, it, or they should be trusted. Unfortunately, we often base our judgments on irrelevant considerations. Physical characteristics, for example, tell us little about a person's credibility or its lack. Does a person look you in the eye? Does he perspire a lot? Does he have a nervous laugh? Despite being generally worthless in this regard, such characteristics are widely used in sizing up a person's credibility. Simply being taller, louder, and more assertive can enhance a person's credibility, according to a Stanford study.* A practiced con artist can imitate a confident teller of the truth, just as an experienced hacker can cobble up a genuine-appearing website. ("Con," after all, is short for "confidence.")

Other irrelevant features we sometimes use to judge a person's credibility include gender, age, ethnicity, accent, and mannerisms. People also make credibility judgments on the basis of the clothes a person wears. A friend told one of us that one's sunglasses "make a statement"; maybe so, but that statement doesn't say much about credibility. A person's occupation certainly bears a relationship to his or her knowledge or abilities, but as a guide to moral character or truthfulness, it is hardly reliable.

Which considerations are relevant to judging someone's credibility? We will get to these in a moment, but appearance isn't one of them. You may have the idea that you can size up a person just by looking into his or her eyes. This is a mistake. Just by looking at someone, we cannot ascertain that person's truthfulness, knowledge, or character. (Although this is generally true, there may be rare exceptions. See the "Fib Wizards" box on page 109.)

I looked the man in the eye. I found him to be very straightforward and trustworthy. We had a very good dialogue. I was able to sense his soul.

—George W. Bush, commenting on his first meeting with Russian president Vladimir Putin

**Bush later changed his mind about Putin, seeing him as a threat to democracy. So much for the "blink" method of judging credibility.**

## Does Your Face Give You Away?

Some researchers, like Alan Stevens in Australia, believe that conclusions about your character and health can be drawn from your facial structures. Here are some examples:

**Face width:** A man with a wide face (they say) generally has higher levels of testosterone and is more likely to be aggressive than one with a narrower face.

**Cheek size:** Fuller cheeks (they say) may indicate a person's greater likelihood of catching illnesses and infections. According to Benedict Jones at Glasgow University, larger-cheeked people are more likely to be depressed or anxious.

Win McNamee/Getty Images

**Nose size and shape:** A large nose supposedly indicates a person is ambitious, confident, and self-reliant, a born leader. People who have neutral nose tips—neither round nor sharp—are said to be sweet, mild-tempered, and have endearing personalities.

We have our doubts. There may be weak associations between genetically determined facial structures and not-entirely-genetically-determined character traits, but we don't need to look at Santa's nose to know he is sweet.

From http://www.bustle.com/articles/110866-what-your-facial-features-say-about-you-according-to-science . Also see *In Your Face: What Facial Features Reveal About People You Know and Love,* by Bill Cordingley.

*The study, conducted by Professor Lara Tiedens of the Stanford University Graduate School of Business, was reported in *USA Today,* July 18, 2007.

## War-Making Policies and Interested Parties

In the 1960s, the secretary of defense supplied carefully selected information to President Lyndon Johnson and to Congress. Would Congress have passed the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, which authorized the beginning of the Vietnam War, if its members had known that the secretary of defense was determined to begin hostilities there? We don't know, but certainly they and the president should have been more suspicious if they had known this fact. Would President Bush and his administration have been so anxious to make war on Iraq if they had known that Ahmad Chalabi, one of their main sources of information about that country and its ruler, Saddam Hussein, was a very interested party? (He hoped to be the next ruler of Iraq if Hussein were overthrown, and much of his information turned out to be false or exaggerated.) We don't know that either, of course. But it's possible that more suspicion of interested parties may have slowed our commitment to two costly wars.

Of course, we sometimes get in trouble even when we accept credible claims from credible sources. Many rely, for example, on credible advice from qualified and honest professionals in preparing our tax returns. But qualified and honest professionals can make honest mistakes, and we can suffer the consequences. In general, however, trouble is much more likely if we accept either doubtful claims from credible sources or credible claims from doubtful sources (not to mention doubtful claims from doubtful sources). If a mechanic says we need a new transmission, the claim itself may not be suspicious—maybe the car we drive has many miles on it; maybe we neglected routine maintenance; maybe it isn't shifting smoothly. But remember that the mechanic is an interested party; if there's any reason to suspect he or she would exaggerate the problem to get work, we'd get a second opinion.

We fell in love.

—President donald Trump, after his first meeting with North Korean dictator Kim Jung-Un.

**As of this writing, it isn't clear that the bromance will last.**

One of your authors has an automobile which the dealership said had an oil leak it would cost almost a thousand dollars to fix. Because he'd not seen oil on his garage floor, your cautious author decided to wait to see how serious the problem was. Well, a year after the "problem" was diagnosed, there was still no oil on the garage floor, and the car had used less than half a quart of oil, about what one would have expected over the course of a year. What to conclude? The dealership is an interested party. If its service rep convinces your author that the oil leak is serious, the dealership makes almost a thousand dollars. This makes it worth a second opinion, or, in this case, the author's own investigation. He now believes his car will never need this thousand-dollar repair.

Remember: Interested parties are less credible than other sources of claims.

### Expertise

Much of our information comes from people about whom we have no reason to suspect prejudice, bias, or any of the other features that make interested parties bad sources. However, we might still doubt a source's actual knowledge of an issue in question. A source's knowledge depends on a number of factors, especially expertise and experience. Just as you generally cannot tell merely by looking at a source whether he or she is speaking truthfully, objectively, and accurately, you can't judge his or her knowledge or expertise by looking at surface features. A British-sounding scientist may appear more knowledgeable than a scientist who speaks, say, with a Texas drawl, but accent, height, gender, ethnicity, and clothing don't bear on a person's knowledge. In the municipal park in our town, it can be difficult to distinguish people who teach at the university from people who live in the park, based on physical appearance.

So, then, how do you judge a person's **expertise?** Education and experience are often the most important factors, followed by accomplishments, reputation, and position, in no particular order. It is not always easy to evaluate the credentials of a source, and credentials vary considerably from one field to another. Still, there are useful guidelines worth mentioning.

Education includes, but is not strictly limited to, formal education—the possession of degrees from established institutions of learning. (Some "doctors" of this and that received their diplomas from mail-order houses that advertise on matchbook covers. The title "doctor" is not automatically a qualification.)

Experience—both the kind and the amount—is an important factor in expertise. Experience is important if it is relevant to the issue at hand, but the mere fact that someone has been on the job for a long time does not automatically make him or her good at it.

Accomplishments are an important indicator of someone's expertise but, once again, only when those accomplishments are directly related to the question at hand. A Nobel Prize winner in physics is not necessarily qualified to speak publicly about toy safety, public school education (even in science), or nuclear proliferation. The last issue may involve physics, it's true, but the political issues are the crucial ones, and they are not taught in physics labs.

A person's reputation is obviously very important as a criterion of his or her expertise. But reputations must be seen in a context; how much importance we should attach to somebody's reputation depends on the people among whom the person has that reputation. You may have a strong reputation as a pool player among the denizens of your local pool hall, but that doesn't necessarily put you in the same league with Jackie Karol. Among a group of people who know nothing about investments, someone who knows the difference between a 401(k) plan and a Roth IRA may seem like quite an expert. But you certainly wouldn't want to take investment advice from somebody simply on that basis.

Most of us have met people who were recommended as experts in some field but who turned out to know little more about that field than we ourselves knew. (Presumably, in such cases those doing the recommending knew even less about the subject, or they would not have been so quickly impressed.) By and large, the kind of reputation that counts most is the one a person has among other experts in his or her field of endeavor.

The positions people hold provide an indication of how well *somebody* thinks of them. The director of an important scientific laboratory, the head of an academic department at Harvard, the author of a work consulted by other experts—in each case the position itself is substantial evidence that the individual's opinion on a relevant subject warrants serious attention.

But expertise can be bought. Our earlier discussion of interested parties applies to people who possess real expertise on a topic as well as to the rest of us. Sometimes a person's position is an indication of what his or her opinion, expert or not, is likely to be. The opinion of a lawyer retained by the National Rifle Association, offered at a hearing on firearms and urban violence, should be scrutinized much more carefully (or at least viewed with more skepticism) than that of a witness from an independent firm or agency that has no stake in the outcome of the hearings. The former can be assumed to be an interested party, the latter not. It is too easy to lose objectivity where one's interests and concerns are at stake, even if one is *trying* to be objective.

Here's a more complicated story: In the 1960s and 1970s, a national concern arose about the relationship between the consumption of sugar and several serious conditions, including diabetes and heart disease. An artificial sweetener, cyclamate, was introduced to replace sugar in sodas and other products. The sugar industry, afraid of lost sales, countered with an assault on cyclamates, and Dr. John Hickson led the charge. Later, when Hickson was research director of the Cigar Research Council, he was described in a confidential memo as "a supreme scientific politician who had been successful in condemning cyclamates, on behalf of the Sugar Research Council, on somewhat shaky evidence."* The substance was banned by the FDA in 1969. A quick web search on "cyclamate ban" will reveal the story: By 1989, FDA officials were admitting they had made a mistake in issuing the ban, which was done under pressure from the U.S. Congress, which in turn was pressured by the sugar industry.

The moral of this story is that politics, and interested parties with deep pockets, can and do influence findings that are supposed to be entirely scientific.

Experts sometimes disagree, especially when the issue is complicated and many different interests are at stake. In these cases, a critical thinker is obliged to suspend judgment about which expert to endorse, unless one expert clearly represents a majority viewpoint among experts in the field or *unless one expert can be established as more authoritative or less biased than the others.*

Of course, majority opinions sometimes turn out to be incorrect, and even the most authoritative experts occasionally make mistakes. For example, various economics experts predicted good times ahead just before the Great Depression. The same was true for many advisers right up until the 2008 financial meltdown. Jim Denny, the manager of the Grand Ole Opry, fired Elvis Presley after one performance, stating that Presley wasn't going anywhere and ought to go back to driving a truck. A claim you accept because it represents the majority viewpoint or comes from the most authoritative expert may turn out to be thoroughly wrong. Nevertheless, take heart: At the time, you were rationally justified in accepting the majority viewpoint as the most authoritative claim.

A case in point is that of climate change, a hot button topic one is reluctant to wade into. According to NASA (The National Aeronautics and Space Administration, an independent agency of the United States Federal Government responsible for the civilian space program, aeronautics and aerospace research), 97 percent or more of actively publishing climate scientists agree that climate-warming trends over the past century are extremely likely due to human activities. In addition (according to NASA) "most of the leading scientific organizations worldwide have issued public statements endorsing this position."** Some fairly visible sources who believe that global warming doesn't exist or if it does is not caused by human activities concede that theirs is a minority opinion among scientists, but think the majority opinion is mistaken. They cite possible errors in temperature measurements and computer modeling.*** For the layperson who cannot possibly review all the data for himself or herself, the most reasonable position is one that agrees with the most authoritative opinion but allows for enough open-mindedness to change if the authoritative opinion changes.

*http://legacy.library.ucsf.edu/tid/bon57a99.

**https://climate.nasa.gov/scientific-consensus/

***https://www.heartland.org/multimedia/videos-climate-change/man-caused-global-warming-the-greatest-scam-in-world-history

## Not Paying Attention to Experts Can Be Deadly

Sean Thomforde/Shutterstock

> david Pawlik called the fire department in Cleburne, Texas, in July to ask if the "blue flames" he and his wife were seeing every time she lit a cigarette were dangerous, and an inspector said he would be right over and for Mrs. Pawlik not to light another cigarette. However, Mrs. Pawlik lit up anyway and was killed in the subsequent explosion. (The home was all electric, but there had been a natural gas leak underneath the yard.)
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> —*Fort Worth Star Telegram,* **July 11, 2007**

Mother knows best? Take the word of the experts.

Finally, we sometimes make the mistake of thinking that whatever qualifies someone as an expert in one field automatically qualifies that person in other areas. Being a top-notch programmer, for example, might not be an indication of top-notch management skills. Indeed, many programmers may get good at what they do by shying away from dealing with other people—or so the stereotype runs. Being a good campaigner may not always translate into being a good office-holder. Even if the intelligence and skill required to become an expert in one field could enable someone to become an expert in any field—which is doubtful—having the ability to become an expert is not the same as actually being an expert. Claims put forth by experts about subjects outside their fields are not automatically more acceptable than claims put forth by nonexperts.